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Germaine Bazzle

Germaine Bazzle plays an important role in the musical life of New Orleans as an educator, vocalist and mentor. She embraces all genres of music in her teaching and shares the bandstand with the best of the city's jazz artists. Germaine visited Rome, New York as an instructor with the Louis Armstrong Jazz Camp.

Germaine was interviewed in Rome, New York on August 21, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Rome, New York. I'm very pleased to have Germaine Bazzle with me. Welcome.

GB: Thank you.

MR: Welcome to Rome. And before we were rolling we were talking about your trip up from New Orleans and we're pleased to have you here at the Rome Y camp. It seems like you put a lot of soul into your teaching and the reason I say that is I was eavesdropping while you were teaching.

GB: Oh you were, oh.

MR: I was looking through the window and you really looked like you were involved with those students who you had only just met. How do you warm up so quickly to music students?

GB: Oh wow. First of all I didn't know that you were peeping. But you know when you work with children, children are so open to you. You know they really open their arms because they come to you without any — what shall I say — blockings or anything, any trappings that come to you, very wide open. And these young people came to me this morning very wide open and ready to learn, you know, about what we do insofar as the scatting and that kind of thing. Because that's what they were truly curious about. And they came here with that kind of an anticipation so I had no choice but to try to answer that for them and to convince them that they are capable of doing that, of doing the scatting. Because it seemed like it was a mystery to them but by the time we got throughout little tunes this afternoon they were beginning to feel comfortable and to feel free and they began to understand about the improvisational side of what we do. So because when I see that from them — that kind of interest, that kind of spirit — you know it makes you want to keep driving and get more and more and more and more. So what you saw, I was asking for more and more and more.

MR: It even seemed like you were doing some movement things with them.

GB: Yes. Um hum. Yes.

MR: Why is that part of your teaching?

GB: Because I want them to understand that music involves the entire being, you know. It's not just a spiritual thing, it's not just a physical thing. It's all of you. I mean every part of your being works with this and to get them to understand the concept of swinging, of the swinging. It's clapping, it's patting your feet, that kind of thing. And when you're singing, for me, I find that when I ask them to swing I'm asking you to dig in there and just let your soul be free and give me two and four. Just give me that swing on two and four you know. And it made a difference and the song that we were learning today, one of them, "Pick Yourself Up," and we learned the lyrics and all. Then I said to them, "Clap while you sing it." I said, "I want you to clap one, two, three, four, one." So they sang it clapping one, two, three, four. Okay. Now clap it and sing and clap on one and three. One, three, one, three. I said now clap and sing on two and four. I said, "Now which one felt better?" They said, "Two and four." I said that's it. So to get them to understand that. It's not rocket science, it's just digging and dealing with what you have and being natural with it and being free to do that. And this is because I am told that I am a physical singer, and they're right.

MR: And physical in movement but also I think that must mean something beyond that you move around stage.

GB: Yeah, right, yeah, yeah. It's more than that, it's more than that. But it's almost to the point where I'm conducting you know, because the guys tell me, "I saw that shoulder moving." I say, "You did, yeah." So whatever the shoulder means, and I'm singing, whatever they get out of that shoulder, fine you know. If it's going to bring us in and it's going to make us tighter, fine. I don't know what it means. They say, "Well when you're singing you shake your leg" you know. I say, "Well I'm keeping time." No there's something else that's happening when you do that. What am I communicating? I don't know but whatever it is that they understand it to communicate, that's it. But the whole thing, Monk, is it's got to swing. It's got to swing. And if I feel like I'm losing that then I know I am.

MR: And the part that you were talking about doing, the clapping thing, which I think I probably will steal that by the way because — it's funny when people start clapping on one and three, I sometimes don't know how to deal with that. So I love your — ask them which feels better. Did you have someone when you were a young person helping you learn?

GB: Well I had records. You know those youngsters don't know about these thirty-three and a thirds you know. But that's what we had. And Ella Fitzgerald, Sarah Vaughan, Charlie Parker, Miles Davis. You know because we listened a lot and I told the students this this afternoon. For me to learn how to do what I do, especially with the scatting, came from

listening to instrumentalists more than vocalists. As much as I enjoyed and learned from Ella and Sarah and all those ladies, at one time I had to stop listening to them because I found myself almost trying to do their things, doing their music. And I said but it's not mine. It's not me yet. So listening to instrumentalists and learning their solos and then learning everybody's solo on the recording, that was the challenge. And then being able to sing those solos while you're doing the dishes or whatever, without the recordings you see. That was the challenge. And there was a group of us in school, I mean that's what it was. We'd sit in what we call the co-op at the university — it was like a little café or something. And we'd sit in the co-op and we'd sing these songs and okay, you take Bird's solo, you take Miles' solo and it was great fun. It was great fun. I never imagined I would be using it now but at the time I mean I just liked jazz and you just sing it. But I never thought I'd be using it in this manner.

MR: If you were doing a Charlie Parker solo and then you were trying to do a Miles solo, would you choose different syllables to pull that solo off?

GB: Good question. I'm inclined to go with the sound okay, as opposed to syllable. For instance if [scats] if I'm trying to get into one of Bird's things I would be inclined to try and match his tone, the sound of his horn, as opposed to using a syllable. And with the horn it's [scats] that kind of thing. I'm more inclined towards that, which I discovered what maybe a couple of years ago. Because I didn't realize how much those guys were influencing me. Are you following what I'm saying?

MR: Yeah, yeah.

GB: You know, so much so that on the gigs I said you know what? I'm not going to use any syllables I'm just going to try to get the sound. And when I started doing that I realized that I was bringing another sound to the whole ensemble, okay?

MR: Well musicians talk about singers in that regard sometimes. They say well she's like having another horn in the band.

GB: Um hum. Yes.

MR: I remember people saying that about Joe Williams who we knew pretty well.

GB: Um hum. Yes.

MR: That he was like another horn in the band. Is that a compliment to you?

GB: I think so.

MR: Okay.

GB: I think so because I know that I'm limited in that sound but wherever I am, whatever I can do within my range, I think that's — oh that's a wonderful compliment which means I was able to pull it off. But now I'm working with a group at home and the tenor player and I, whenever anybody is taking a solo he and I will get together and we'll do some kind of little riff.

MR: Oh good.

GB: You know, a little background riff or something like that. And it's all a joy. It's all a joy for me.

MR: Having — being educated in music, does it help you in a band situation because you know — I'm trying to figure out how to say this correctly. You know chords and you know forms, perhaps more than some singers who are sort of just singing innately. Is it helpful to you that you have that music education background?

GB: Oh yes, yes, yes. Very much so. Because there are just little things that I learned in the training that I use. For instance if I'm doing harmony with the horn player and he's using a vibrato, okay, then I think that I should match his vibrato to make it even closer. You know? And I'll listen to his breathing, where he's phrasing, so that we can phrase alike. So much of this stuff happens, you know, it's impromptu, you know, it's improvisational. So to make it sound more like a unit and all of this, those are the little things that I listen for. Had I not had the training in choral singing and breathing and phrasing and listening — because I used to play bass you know — and listening to the bands and all of this and what the people were doing, I don't think I would be as aware, you know, of those little secrets. Sometimes if we're doing a tune and maybe we're not doing it exactly as it's supposed to be rhythmically, but I'll listen to what the horn guy is doing and if he's going to do a little syncopated thing instead of right on, I'm going to match that, I'm going to work with that. Because it's all about making the music. It's all about making the music and making that sound you know. And it's all about — how shall I say — experiencing a oneness.

MR: That becomes more possible if you're able to work with the same group consistently. Are you able to do that in New Orleans?

GB: No, no.

MR: It's hard isn't it?

GB: Which is even more of a challenge now. Because I work with a group now that I've been working with for a while, but it's only on that one night. But I may work at Snug Harbor with a whole different group of musicians you know, and I may work at the hotel with another group of musicians. Mind you now somewhere along the line I have worked with all of them, but not necessarily that particular grouping. So we are sensitive to each other but it's always that little unexpected thing, that little surprise thing, that little thing that you're always looking for that kicks it, puts that extra little spice in it, that makes it work. So even if I'm not working with the same group all of the time if I work with another tenor player when something is going on and I'll walk over to him and say, "Well let's try this riff," you know. And he says, "Okay." And I'll sing the riff through one time and he comes in and he does a harmony on it and then we flip flop you know.

MR: That's great.

GB: Oh it's fun.

MR: And it adds so much to the experience for the listeners I think.

GB: Um hum, yes.

MR: You know the astute listener and watcher will even see that happen, see you walk over and hum something and then I mean that's great.

GB: Yes it is. And I was blessed to be a part of a group with Alvin "Red" Tyler who is a great, wonderful musician in New Orleans. And I learned a lot from him. Sometimes we were on the gig and he'd play a little riff and he'd look at me. It was no words. He'd just play this little riff and he'd look at me and I'd say okay here we go [scats] and I'm trying to find a third or something to do it with him in thirds. And that's — I learned that from him. I learned a lot from him. But that's one of the little secrets. And we called them "Red Tylerisms" you know the little things that he used to do.

MR: Was music part of your life from a young age?

GB: Yes. Um hum. I grew up in a home where there was music all of the time. My dad played piano, my mom played, and my aunts and uncles played, and there was a song called "Sweet Sue" that my dad used to play all of the time. And I learned to play that song. I guess I must have been about nine or ten years old. And two years later my mom decided that I should have some formal training and it went from that. But there was always music.

MR: When did you become aware of the heritage and history of your city, or did it make an impression on you that you lived there? Sometimes people who live in a certain area that's known for something don't become aware of it as much as those of us that were reading about it from outside.

GB: Let me answer that this way. I became aware of it because of some things that happened in New Orleans, the Mardi Gras. Okay? My parents were in a marching club. So at Mardi Gras they dressed in these costumes and had the band and they marched around. And I grew up with that. And it was understood that this is a part of you, this is a part of what we do, you know, you don't have to embrace it but you have to be aware of it. Then being around, living in a neighborhood where there were many musicians and you'd hear these guys practicing, you know, you're sitting on the front porch hearing them practice, you know, playing with their kids and hearing the band practicing in the back yard or something like that. You grew up with that and it was not anything to be — at least I didn't take it for granted. Because I felt good when I did it. And I can remember even as a child feeling good when I did the music, even to the point where I'd put the turntable on and I'm washing the dishes or something like this, it's always music. And then I decided that I wanted to do what I saw the Nicholas Brothers do and tapping and getting on the

kitchen table and tapping and looking and seeing my father peek around the door. You know and I'm sharing all of these little things with you because that's how much music was in my life or is in my life now. And as I got older I moved into an area called like the Tremé area of our city where a lot of the music is and where it really came from. You know we have these second lines and the parades and all of this and the people are dancing in the street and all, and then I had the opportunity to go to Preservation Hall and watch all of these older people playing this music. And you start making the connection. If you can see the Humphrey Brothers and all of these guys over here in Preservation Hall and maybe walk six or seven blocks away and see the youngsters doing the same theme, there's that connection right there. There's no denying it. There's no denying what that music is. And the older I get the more important it becomes that I pass this on to youngsters so that they can understand that this is ours, this is a part of our culture. This is what we have brought to America. We've brought this to America. We had all of the European music come to us. But we brought this. We brought this out of Congo Square. We brought this from the Dominican Republic. We brought this from all of these places and now you have all of these rhythms going on. You know. And it's exciting that you're responding to rhythms and rhythms and rhythms you know. Okay I'm getting excited.

MR: No, no, no. You said that very well. My wife and I were in New Orleans just about a year ago. And we were walking I think on Canal Street I guess, and we could hear this sound of this band and we literally followed the sound. And then on the corner of I guess Bourbon Street there was this group of young kids playing. And they were unbelievable. You couldn't possibly write down what they were playing. And I just thought that was a joy to see, that that still goes on. Is there any organization to that kind of street corner playing that you're aware of? Is there a hierarchy or something in how that happens?

GB: I don't know. Let me put it this way. It's just that this guy says to this child, "Take this horn and I'm going to teach you how to play this, I'm going to teach you how to play that." And the little child struggles with it and finally he learns how to play and then you get another kid together. You know it's coming out of the neighborhoods. It's coming out of the neighborhoods. And it's not necessarily that you're teaching them to read at that point, it's just teaching them to respond to what's naturally within. And we have many, many, many musicians who started that way, little ones, they say, young men — what's this child's name now — Troy Andrews.

MR: Oh, the "Trombone Shorty" they call him.

GB: Yes. "Trombone Shorty." Okay now the trombone was bigger than he was when he started playing and he was maybe about that tall but he was playing that horn and he was getting this big sound. I remember I used to sing with the St. Louis Cathedral Choir. And we'd do a ten o'clock mass at the Cathedral. And one Sunday I came out of mass and I

heard this music but I didn't see these people. And I went to the corner and it's all these little boys, little boys. Trombone Shorty with the trombone and a little kid with the trumpet. And I imagine they were like nine, ten years old. There was a whole band of these kids. I got so excited I ran inside to the rectory and I said, "You guys got to come out here and see this." And I think that the older gentlemen, the older players, just sort of took them in hand and said okay learn these songs, learn these songs. And these kids just started playing and playing and finally they got into where they were going to the training, they got into the formal bit, but they never lost, they never lost that root thing. They never lost that feeling, that spirit. No matter what they play. No matter what they play. Whether they're playing the traditional or they're playing the blues or they're playing straight ahead jazz or whatever, that feeling is still there.

MR: This group I mentioned started playing "Stand By Me," you know? And what they did with it was indescribable. But it was so great, and they just went on forever — the endurance even, wow.

GB: Yes, oh yes.

MR: Did you have any trouble when you started formal music lessons with the fact that you had — I'm guessing that you had developed a very good ear by the time you started doing that. Was that a help or a hindrance?

GB: It was a help.

MR: Good.

GB: It was a help. It helped with the sight singing, and then too it helped because I played the bass. That also helped the ear you know. I started playing the bass when I was about twelve okay. And all of those things just helped me to develop a fairly decent ear.

MR: Was there a point that you can remember where you made a conscious sort of career decision about — okay music's definitely in me. Now what am I going to do with it?

GB: Okay. I didn't have that choice. Okay? Talking about a career decision. It had to be music. It was music. I feel that my calling is to teach it. Okay? Performing — that's the bonus side of it. But my calling is to teach. Therefore that's where my commitment has been, to teaching, teaching, teaching. Now what I learned in performing I bring to the classroom. What I learn in the classroom I bring to performing you see. But teaching is the thing that I really believe that I've been called to do. And I tried to stop, I tried to stop. I taught for about twelve years and I said I don't want to do this anymore. I don't want to be in the classroom anymore. I'll just go on and do the gigs. But there was something missing so I started teaching privately, teaching at home. But it still was not enough. Then I got a call to go to the school where I am now and as soon as I walked in the classroom I said —

MR: I'm home, right?

GB: Yeah. Right.

MR: What grade levels do you teach?

GB: Nine through twelve. High school. And it was just like a good deep sigh, whew.

MR: Isn't that interesting.

GB: And I love teaching choral music, I really do. But that's what it's turned out to be. But I can still do the gigs you see. I can still sing with the choirs. But I still have — because again, as I said, what I learn in performing I bring back to the classroom. Because certainly maybe something that you saw me doing this evening, had I not been a performer I would not have been able to bring that kind of punch. You know what I'm saying?

MR: Um hum. Absolutely. And it makes you, especially if your students can see you perform on occasion, I think it really makes you legitimate in their eyes and gives way to what you pass on to them. And you don't have to depend on gigs to pay the rent.

GB: True, oh yeah.

MR: What do you tell aspiring students about that these days when they come to you and they just want to be a star?

GB: Okay. One of the things that I emphasize to them is to be sure that they talk to their parents about this. Because it's a decision that they have to make, whether the parents are going to support them with that or not. Okay. What are the parents expecting out of them. If you follow music as a career, are the parents willing to support you with that? The other thing is be prepared, you've got to study. You know there are some of us who were born with innate talent you know, but it's not enough. You've got to have some musical training. You've got to learn how to use the voice as opposed to abusing the voice. It's to your advantage to know what key you're singing the song in. It's to your advantage to know the tempo that you want. It's to your advantage to know about dynamics. It's to your advantage to understand that, you know, this horn has to transpose, you know, so that you will know just what's going to happen when you do this tune. It's to your advantage — so the training is important. But even besides all of that, how real can you be with your performance? How honest can you be? How honest can you be with yourself when you are performing? Because your audience demands honesty.

MR: What makes honesty in a performance for you? Is that possible to put into words?

GB: I think it only comes through your performance. If you can take the material that you have and make it your own and be willing to stand emotionally nude before a group of people, they will get it and they will know that you are for real. They will know it's honest. You can't fool them.

MR: Do you think people try to do that before they're ready, when they're too young?

GB: To do?

MR: To do, to be — well I guess I'm thinking of — maybe I didn't ask that right, but this phenomenon about American Idol and the over-use I believe of the term "diva" over the years. I wonder how that affects impressionable young aspiring people?

GB: Yes. I understand the question. I watch American Idol. I watch it primarily because I work with young people. Some of it I don't particularly care for but then that's not me. You know, it's not about me it's about them. And I understand young people having that ambition and having that goal, but you've got to prepare for it. That's a rough, rough business. And I'm not just talking about just musically. You've got to be prepared to take the rough edges, you know, the rough comments. You have to be prepared to cry, you know? You have to be prepared to accept some of the things that are going to come down the pike with that. Why? Because if you pursue this career you're going to run into that same thing. You're going to run into that same thing. Criticisms, people don't like you, people will say things about you — true or untrue. People will do things to hurt you. They will do things to — how should I say, I don't want to say, what's the word — to keep you from being successful, out of jealousy, out of envy. You know, those kind of things, and you've got to be ready for that. And I think that some of our young people are not ready for that side of it. And so when I watch that program and I listen to the young people and I think that there are some demands being put on them that they're not ready for. I wonder if after rehearsals if they can speak, you know? Because sometimes the demands are such that you've got to give me this big, big sound and we can do it over and over and over and over until you get it. Well, whew. I need a break. I need to be able to be quiet. I shouldn't be hoarse when I finish singing. So I don't know how they do it, you know, with the young people. I don't know how much they demand of them. But I think that some of the material does not suit the singer. I really do.

MR: That's a good answer. It must be a little tricky sometimes when parents come to you also. Have they ever come and said, "Do you think my daughter should be pursuing a professional career in music?"

GB: There are some, now in all honesty there are some young people, I mean you see it now, that they're going to be a star. I mean you see it now. But they're learning now. They're getting the training now. They're not waiting until they get 19, 20 and 21 to start the training. The training is starting at 9, 10, 11, 12. So that by the time they get of the age of majority, if you will, by the time they get there, they've had a lot of groundwork there. And so those are the ones who will be able to survive I think. But I don't think it works very well when you're 19 and you want to go on the stage at 19-1/2. Because they're in a hurry. And you have to have patience in preparing for this. But many of them are in a hurry. You know they want to hurry up and get it so they can hurry up and do this or they

can hurry up and do that. You know, so they can hurry up. And when you get to the point where you can't hurry anymore then what do you have to fall back on?

MR: Do students in — are you in a public school?

GB: No, I'm in a private school.

MR: In a private school, they have a lot of musical opportunities in that private school?

GB: Um hum. Yes. And you know we have I think a pretty good fine arts department. We have piano and instrumental music and vocal music and drama and art and all of that kind of thing. And those of us who are in that department, we actually — we work together so that our kids are benefiting from all of the areas, so that a person who is sitting down watching the speaker, the person who is a singer sitting down watching the speaker has something to go by, to listen to. Notice things. You know, notice the phrasing, notice the enunciation, notice these kinds of things so that you as a singer must understand that that's part of singing, enunciation, phrasing. That's part of it too. Expression. Showing it on your face. That's part of it too. So look at the actor and then project that through your singing. And then it's the same thing. The actor looks at the singer and notices well what's happening here with the dynamics, what are we doing? It works.

MR: Yeah. There's something to learn from every art form.

GB: Yeah. Exactly. Um hum.

MR: Wow. Interesting. In New Orleans, we were talking a little bit on the way in the car about musical opportunities in the various cities. Is there a lot of competition for gigs in the city?

GB: I don't know so much as competition, I don't know. I don't think there's competition because we don't have very many musicians back in New Orleans yet. Because everybody, we're so happy to see each other and we're so happy to hear each other that we're not competing with each other. You know the place where I work on Monday nights, some of the musicians, they come in from Texas. One little fellow I think he's somewhere in Dallas. And he says, "I had to come home, I had to come for at least a weekend, I had to come, I had to come and play." So you know they walk in with their horns. You know some of them they're out the case before they get — so we're not competing at this point anyway. I don't think that we're competing as much as we are enjoying each other and welcoming each other. We're so glad to see each other and share. That's a very special time, especially since Katrina. It's all special. So if there's any competition going on it's between us and the good Lord because we're saying come on Lord, give us more, give us more, give us more, let us do more, let us do more. And when I say that it's coming because I really believe that the music comes from there and goes through — you know we're just the vessel.

MR: I see.

GB: And so we are saying give us more so we can put more of it out, put more of it out. So in that sense I don't think that we are at that competitive stage. Now maybe when everybody gets back, you know, it might be. But right now it's just a joyous time.

MR: A reunion time.

GB: Yes. Um hum.

MR: I doubt there was anybody in the city that was not affected by that. Were you personally affected in a dramatic way?

GB: Well not as dramatic as some people. But I did have the flooding to the extent that we had to gut everything, take out all the walls, even the ceiling, the flooring, because of the water, and had wind damage. Part of my roof was in the driveway and all of that. But that's able to be repaired. It's the people whose homes floated down the street, whose homes just collapsed, their situation is far worse than mine. Because in my area now I was very glad to see that my neighbors are coming back and working on their homes, that kind of thing. But the biggest thing for me is that I have not been able to get in to my own home while they're doing the repairs but I do have a place to live. Okay, I have a place to live. And I'm in New Orleans and I'm back at work. We have people who can't even come back because they don't have a place to live. They would like to come back and work but there's no place to live while they work so they're out there and it's like they're stranded. And there are many people like that. And believe me, believe me, they all want to come back home. They all want to come back home. They all want to work. They all want to be a part of this process of bringing New Orleans back. That's what we're saying, or rebuilding New Orleans. They all want to be a part of that. But you've got to have some place to live while you're doing it.

MR: I just got a mailing from, I'm not sure, Wynton Marsalis is on a big fundraiser coming up and there've been a lot of efforts and I hope that they have positive results for all of you down there.

GB: Yes, yes. Well you know there's a special thing going on, this Habitat for Humanities is doing a thing for a musician's village. So they are — and you know that involves sweat equity and all of that kind of thing so that the musicians who are applying, who have applied for a home, they have to come in and do some work, help them in building their homes. So they are about the business of setting up a place so that the musicians can come back. And they're going to establish a center, an Ellis Marsalis Center in that area for children so that you would teach the children the music. So that's looking good.

MR: I have you on tape here.

GB: Okay.

MR: I just thought I would play a little bit.

GB: Oy oy oy.

MR: I think you'll like it.

GB: Oh my goodness.

[audio interlude]

GB: Oh that's from the jazz fest.

MR: Yes.

GB: That's "A Foggy Day?"

MR: Yes.

GB: Okay.

MR: With Red Tyler.

GB: Yes.

MR: I love this ending.

GB: Oh it's fun. Isn't it fun to do?

MR: I'm guessing okay this was a little like okay what's going to happen?

GB: Yes.

MR: How is this going to end up?

GB: Yes.

MR: Let's find out.

GB: Yeah [scats] that little riff.

MR: I like what the piano player's doing too.

GB: Yeah. I think that's Brian Blade on drums.

MR: You think what?

GB: Brian Blade? I think that's Brian Blade playing drums.

MR: Nicely done.

GB: Thank you. That was fun to do.

MR: I'll bet. And live, everybody together, no overdubbing.

GB: That was not rehearsed.

MR: Not rehearsed even.

GB: Not rehearsed no. That's one of the other things too that happens, that I have been blessed with is having worked with people like that who, whatever you want to do. "What should I do?" "Whatever you want to do, we're right there." So I could take freedoms like we did on this little vamp here you know, just take the freedom and the phrasing, stretching things out, putting that space in between, and they're right there, they're right there you know. As long as I want to keep doing it, they're right there. That's such fun.

MR: And I noticed something, near that ending, and that was when the people you were playing with didn't feel compelled to fill up all that space with — oh here's a space I better fill it.

GB: Yes.

MR: That's important.

GB: Space is just as important as the written note. The rests are important.

MR: Do you have — when you're trying to teach a jazz concept to people who have been trained classically, do they get hung up with worrying about making a mistake?

GB: Yes. And when we're doing ensemble singings arranged you know, you have your four part harmony or whatever, so we have to sing these notes. We have to sing these notes. And we have to sing the rhythm that is there but we can also take liberties. And that's where some of them have — but that's a quarter note and it's followed by an eighth note. Okay that's fine. And here's the rest. Quarter note, eighth note, rest. Yeah that's fine. But suppose I want to make it eighth note, quarter note, rest? What's that going to do to the effect of the tune? What's that going to do to the swing of the tune? So sometimes they're uncomfortable with it until we have it in context and you see where it's coming from, where it's coming from. Let me say something. The Swingle Singers. You are familiar with the Swingles?

MR: Um hum.

GB: I love them. I love them. I love them. And I tried to get a group of people, musicians, especially vocal music teachers, I tried to get a group of them together. Because I wanted to do Swingle Singers. And more than one told me that they didn't think that they could do that. And I said, "Why not?" I can't imagine Bach as a jazz piece. I said, "Back off." Have you really listened? Have you really played I mean just a simple two part invention? Have you really played it, have you really listened to all that's going on in that piece? And I'm not just talking about the dynamics that's written there. I'm just asking you have you really listened to it, the little things that you have going against each other. And all you've got to do is put a back beat to it and it's swinging. Bach swings. And I imagine that I guess I would call Bach the swinginest Baroque musician. I mean really, I mean for the audience, I mean you're playing, your bringing this music for people. You're playing for an audience all the time. You're writing your music for performances. Swingle Singers did it with just a bass and a snare drum and everybody else was singing other parts [scats]. It was right there. And we tried it sometimes. Sometimes I get bold enough to try to do something counter to what the guys are doing. And we have two horns, three horns on the stage you know and I'm doing a tune and it's kind of like a look and I'll say, "Come on, come on, everybody get in, let's just play." You know and everybody is just, we're just free to do this. And that's another kind of experience.

MR: Um hum. You're doing some kind of polyphony there.

GB: There we go.

MR: Well you're in the right city to do it, I mean that's what the pioneers were doing too.

GB: Yes, exactly. Exactly so. And I just know that I don't do it all of the time but the guys have given me permission, so to speak, to say, "Okay guys let's do this." You know "what I'd like us to do this little riff right here." "Okay. And it goes from there. It develops from there. You don't have to have a whole book of stuff, just let it work itself out. And after it's over and the night is over you say oh that was a good night.

MR: Felt good.

GB: Yeah it felt good. Good spirit.

MR: Any new things coming down the pike for you?

GB: Not that I know of. Not that I know of. I'm hoping — there are some things that I'd like to do now that my teaching load has gotten smaller I have a little bit more freedom now to do things. And I'd like to do more jazz festivals. I'd like to go different places. I'm not talking about 90 days anywhere. You know, but go to someplace, do a jazz festival, eat and go back home. Go somewhere else. Once a month maybe. You know a jazz fest a month wouldn't kill me. I still would be able to do it and still work with my kids.

MR: Right. Well I have a feeling that your students are very lucky to have you.

GB: Oh thank you. It's interesting because some of them don't know that I do the jazz bit so we had — sometimes we have groups to come perform at the school and guys called me up one time to sing a song with them. And I started singing and started scatting and one of the students — and she sat that way for the entire song. And when we were finished she came to me and she says, "You fooled me, you fooled me, you don't act like that in the classroom. Why you don't act like that in the classroom?" I said, "It's two different situations." "You fooled me." I said, "Okay, that was fun."

MR: That's neat. Sometimes the impression you make on students is immediate and sometimes it's years later that they realize what it was that they were getting from you.

GB: True. And it is. Because they do come back and they tell you.

MR: Well it's been a fascinating conversation for me.

GB: Well thank you.

MR: I hope you enjoyed it. And I hope I can come back to your city on a Monday night.

GB: Yes.

MR: And come down to your gig.

GB: Yes. Well I want to thank you for the opportunity. Because sometimes I don't know how much I have to say or if I have anything to say but it's a pleasure to be able to share whatever it is that I have.

MR: Well I got a lot off it.

GB: Well thank you. And you gave me some very thoughtful things. Now I've got to go home and think about this. Did I answer that correctly?

MR: Well it's like jazz, there's really no correct answer. There's just different ways to approach it.

GB: Right exactly. Well I thank you so much.